Requirements for the Semester Project

Autumn term 2026

Adapted from the Capstone Project requirements by Prof. Simon Scheidegger (Advanced Data Analytics, HEC Lausanne, 2025).

This document states the requirements. Where it uses "shall" or "must", the requirement is binding: work that does not meet it is not accepted. Practical advice on how to satisfy these requirements — and nothing binding — is in the separate Shipping Guidelines.

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1. What is required

1.1 Each student **shall** individually propose and carry out one project that applies the methods taught in the course to a problem of their own choice.

1.2 The project is **individual**. Joint submissions are not accepted.

1.3 The project accounts for [**100 %**] of the course grade.

2. Deadlines

2.1 The project proposal **shall** be submitted by [**Monday 9 November 2026, 23:59**], Zurich time.

2.2 The complete project **shall** be submitted by [**Sunday 20 December 2026, 23:59**], Zurich time.

2.3 **Late work is not accepted.** A submission made after the deadline in 2.2 receives zero points for the project.

2.4 If the submission platform suffers a verified outage at the deadline, the deadline is extended by the duration of that outage. No other extension is granted except as provided by Faculty regulation.

3. The proposal

3.1 The proposal **shall** be a text of at most **200 words** stating the research question, the data to be used, and the methods to be applied.

3.2 The proposal **shall** be sent by email to the teaching assistant (section 9) by the deadline in 2.1, with the subject line `ADA 2026 proposal - Lastname Firstname`.

3.3 Approval is given by return email. That email is the sign-off.

3.4 A project **may not** be undertaken before the sign-off has been received. Sign-off confirms that the scope and complexity are appropriate; it is not an assessment of the project.

3.5 A student whose proposal is not approved **shall** send a revised proposal within [**five**] working days of being notified.

4. What is submitted

4.1 The work **shall** be delivered as a **Git repository hosted on GitHub**. Files sent as email attachments, uploaded to Moodle, or shared by any other means are not the submission and are not graded. Email is used only to notify the teaching team, as set out in 4.11.

4.2 The repository **shall** contain:

a. a **research paper** in PDF; b. the **data** used, or, where 4.9 applies, the code and instructions that obtain it; c. the **source code** that produces the results; d. a **recording** of approximately **15 minutes** presenting the project, or a working link to it where the file is too large to store in the repository.

4.3 The paper **shall** be about **10 pages**, and **not fewer than 8 pages** excluding references.

4.4 The paper **shall** be typeset in the **SIAM conference style** provided with this document.

4.5 The paper **shall** contain the following sections, in this order:

1. Abstract
2. Introduction
3. The research question and the relevant literature
4. The methodology applied
5. The data set: its source, and how it was cleaned
6. The implementation
7. Results
8. Conclusion
9. Appendix: declaration of tools used (see section 5)

4.6 Further sections **may** be added where the project warrants them.

Identification

4.7 The GitHub account used **shall** display the student's **full name** as registered at the University, in the account's profile name.

4.8 A submission from an account that cannot be matched to a registered student is **not graded**. The teaching team is not required to guess who an account belongs to, and a pseudonymous account with no full name is the student's own failure to submit identifiably.

Access and timing

4.9 Where licence or size prevents including the data itself, the repository **shall** contain the code and instructions by which the data can be obtained, together with a statement of the licence.

4.10 The repository **shall** be [**private, with the teaching assistant added as a collaborator**], and **shall** remain accessible to the teaching team until the grade is final.

4.11 By the deadline in 2.2 the student **shall** send one email to the teaching assistant, with the subject line `ADA 2026 submission - Lastname Firstname`, containing:

a. the repository URL; and b. the **full 40-character identifier (SHA) of the commit** being submitted.

4.12 The submitted work is **the commit named in 4.11(b)**, and nothing else. Commits made after the deadline are not considered, and changes to the repository after the deadline do not change what is graded.

4.13 The teaching team archives each submitted commit shortly after the deadline. From that point the archived copy is the record. If the named commit cannot be found in the repository at that time — because it was never pushed, or because the history was rewritten — the submission is treated as not made.

4.14 The student **shall not** remove the repository, make it inaccessible, or rewrite its history before the grade is final.

5. Declaration of tools

5.1 Generative AI tools and code assistants **may** be used for writing code and prose.

5.2 Every such tool used **shall** be listed in the appendix required by 4.5(9), with a statement of what it was used for.

5.3 An undeclared tool is a breach of these requirements and is treated as academic misconduct under Faculty regulation.

5.4 The student remains the author of, and answerable for, everything submitted. Being unable to explain submitted work is assessed as the student's own failure to meet 6.1.

6. Code the student did not write

6.1 A reader **shall** be able to establish, for any part of the submission, whether the student wrote it and, if not, where it came from. This is the whole of the requirement; the clauses below say how to meet it.

6.2 **No attribution is needed** for published libraries and packages used as intended. Calling `pandas`, `scikit-learn` or `matplotlib` is using a tool, not reusing someone's work.

6.3 **Material from this course** — lecture notebooks, exercise solutions, demonstration code — **may** be reused freely and **shall** be identified where it is used. No licence statement is needed for it.

6.4 **Everything else the student did not write shall be attributed** where it appears, by a comment naming the source and, where one exists, a link; and listed in the appendix required by 4.5(9). This covers code from repositories, articles, forums, answers, textbooks, replication packages accompanying papers, and any other person.

6.5 Reused code **shall** be permitted by its licence, and that licence **shall** be named in the appendix. Code whose licence does not permit the use is not submitted.

6.6 **Code produced by a generative tool** is attributed by naming the tool and what it was asked to produce. The student remains responsible for that code, including where the tool reproduced existing work without saying so. Where such code is later identified, this declaration is what separates an honest mistake from misconduct — which is the practical reason to make it.

6.7 **Code whose origin the student cannot state shall not be submitted.** If it was copied from a source that is no longer remembered, or inherited from someone else's file, it cannot be attributed, and therefore cannot appear in the submission.

6.8 **Not permitted in any circumstance:** code taken from another student's project in this course, and code taken from a project submitted in a previous year.

6.9 **Attribution costs no marks.** Declared reuse is assessed on what the student built with it. Undeclared reuse is academic misconduct under Faculty regulation, whatever its size — the offence is the silence, not the borrowing.

6.10 A project that is substantially an existing analysis re-run on different data is **not** misconduct where it is declared under 6.4. It is assessed under 7.2(b) and 7.2(c) as a project of limited complexity and originality.

7. Assessment

7.1 The project is assessed on the evidence it gives that the student can apply what was taught in the course.

7.2 Assessment weighs three factors:

a. compliance with sections 2 to 5; b. the **complexity** of the project; c. the **originality** of the project and of its presentation.

7.3 **Negative results are acceptable.** A project that states a hypothesis, tests it honestly and finds no effect **may** receive full marks, provided the work and its account are sound. Data or results adjusted to produce an effect are academic misconduct.

8. Publication of project work

8.1 The teaching team **may** publish a project — in whole or in part — on the course website, **only** with the student's written consent.

8.2 Consent is **optional**. It is given or withheld at submission, has no effect on the grade, and the choice is not visible to the assessor before the grade is recorded.

8.3 Consent **may** be withdrawn at any time, in writing, without giving a reason. The material is then removed from the website.

8.4 Published work is credited to its author unless the student requests publication without their name.

9. Questions

9.1 Questions about these requirements are directed to the teaching assistant, **Anna Smirnova** (anna.smirnova@unil.ch).

9.2 The course is taught by **Prof. Dimitrios Karyampas** (dimitrios.karyampas@unil.ch).

Open items — decide before publishing

- [**100 %**] — confirm the project still carries the whole grade in 2026.
- **Tell students about 4.7 early, and more than once.** A GitHub account named `xX_trader_99_Xx` is the normal state of a first-year account, and renaming it takes ten seconds — but only if the student knows before the deadline that it matters. Put it in the first lecture, in the proposal sign-off email, and in the Moodle announcement.
- **Both dates** — confirm against the Faculty calendar.
- **Write the archiving script before December** (4.13). It reads the submission emails, clones each repository at the named commit, and stores the result with a timestamp. Without it, clause 4.13 is a promise the team has to keep by hand at the worst possible time of year, and the clause is the only thing standing between a grade and ”but I pushed the fix on the 21st”.

- **Repository access (4.10)** — private with the TA as collaborator, or public? Private protects student work but means adding each student by hand. Public is no work at all, and is defensible here because the project is individual and the paper is the graded artifact — but it makes every submission visible to every other student while they are still working.
- **Clause 8** is new. It exists because a project gallery cannot be built from work submitted without permission to publish it. Consent must be collected in the same act as submission, this year — it cannot be obtained retroactively once students have finished the course and gone.